

ILLINOIS TECH | College of Computing

Ch10: The Digital Divide, Democracy, And Work P3: Cybertechnology & Democracy



74

Announcements

- Internet 02 section- clarification
- Final Exam

75

Learning Objectives

Upon completion of this lesson the students should be able to:

- Define the **Digital Divide**
 - ❖ Describe and discuss the moral and ethical issues that define and surround the Digital Divide and proposals for its resolution
- Describe and discuss issues surrounding **making technology available to people with disabilities**
- Discuss the effect of **technology on racism**
- Discuss the impact of **technology on gender issues**
 - ❖ Describe and discuss gender issues in employment in the technology field
- Explain and discuss the impact of **technology on democracy and democratic values**
- Describe how technology has **transformed the nature of work and discuss its impact on the quality of work life**

76

Module Objectives

Upon completion of this lesson the students should be able to:

- Explain and discuss the impact of **technology on democracy and democratic values**

77

Cybertechnology, Democracy, and Democratic Ideals

- We have already analyzed equity-and-access issues pertaining to social/economic class (the digital divide), race, gender, and disabled persons.
- Underlying many of the concerns involving these socio-demographic groups are issues that also affect democracy, more broadly, as well as democratic ideals and values in particular.
- A number of interesting questions arise at the intersection of democracy and cybertechnology.

78

Cybertechnology and Democracy

- We examine two different kinds of questions affecting cybertechnology and democracy:
 - 1) has the use of cybertechnology thus far enhanced democracy and democratic ideals, or has it threatened them?
 - 2) what impact has cybertechnology had so far on the political-election process in democratic nations?

79



Democracy and Democratic Ideals

- Democracy, when compared to alternative forms of government, seems an attractive political structure and, arguably, one of the fairest.
- Because of these assumptions, Graham (1999) points out that it is difficult to get people, especially in the Western world, to engage in a serious debate about the merits of democracy.
- He correctly notes that democracy, along with its corresponding notion of a “democratic ideal,” has won almost universal and largely unquestioning acceptance in the West.

80



Democracy and Democratic Ideals

- Graham also notes that some political theorists and philosophers have not always regarded democracy as the best form of government.
- For example, in *The Republic*, Plato was highly critical of democratic government and viewed it as a form of mob rule in which important decisions could be made by a citizenry that typically was not well informed on matters involving the state.
- Even as late as the nineteenth century, philosopher John Stuart Mill questioned whether democracy was the ideal form of government.

81



Democracy and Cybertechnology

- We can assume, for the sake of argument, that democracy is superior to alternative political structures.
- We ask whether cybertechnology favors democracy and democratic ideals.
- Authors who believe that it does generally point to one or more of four factors, where the Internet is alleged to provide greater:
 - 1) “openness” (i.e., an open architecture),
 - 2) empowerment,
 - 3) choice,
 - 4) access to information.

82



Does Cybertechnology Threaten Democracy?

- Introna and Nissenbaum (2000) suggest that Internet search engines threaten democracy because they “systematically exclude certain sites and certain types of sites, in favor of others” – a practice that they believe privileges some groups and some persons at the expense of others.
- Diaz (2008) raises a related concern when he asks whether Internet search technologies will filter out, and thus exclude, the kinds of “independent voices and diverse viewpoints” that are essential for a democracy.

83



Does Cybertechnology Threaten Democracy?

- Pariser (2011) believes that “personalization filters,” which are now used by major search engines, threaten democracy by contributing to political fragmentation and polarization.
- He also fears that “personalization filters” are already having a negative impact for democratic societies because they enable a kind of “invisible autopropaganda,” which can indoctrinate us with our own ideas.

84



Personalization Filters and Social/ Political Fragmentation

- Pariser notes that while democracy “requires citizens to see things from one another’s point of view,” we are instead increasingly “more enclosed in our own bubbles.”
- He also points out that while a democracy “requires a reliance on shared facts,” we are instead being presented with “parallel but separate universes.”

85



Social/Political Fragmentation and Polarization in Democracies

- To show why is this trend away from citizens having shared facts so dangerous for a democracy, Pariser examines the contentious debate about climate change in the U.S. that has taken place during the past decade.
- He notes that studies show that between 2001 and 2010:
- the views of people's beliefs about whether the climate was warming changed significantly, according to one's political party affiliation (Republican vs. Democrat).
- the number of Republicans who believed that the planet was warming fell from 49 to 29 percent, while the number of Democrats rose from 60 to 70 percent.

86



Political Fragmentation and Polarization in Democracies

- One might ask how such a discrepancy regarding beliefs about climate change is possible among people living in the same country.
- Pariser notes that an online search for "climate change" will turn up different results for persons that the search algorithm understands to be:
- an environmental activist vs. an oil company executive;
- a Democrat vs. a Republican.

87



Polarization and Deliberative Democracy

- With entrenched views about current controversial topics such as climate change, citizens in democratic countries such as the U.S. are becoming increasingly polarized.
- Sunstein (2001, 2007) worries that increased polarization threatens *deliberative democracy* – i.e., the process of rationally debating issues in a public forum.
- He suggests that deliberative democracy may suffer irreparable harm because of the ways in which the Internet now filters information.

88



The Impact of Cybertechnology on Political Elections in Democratic Nations?

- We examine this impact in terms of two broad categories – i.e., the use of:
 - a) electronic devices and social media sites to influence political outcomes;
 - b) political blogs to spread (false) information and influence election outcomes.

89



The Use of Electronic Devices and Social Media

- Review Scenario 10-1 in the textbook, which describes a political uprising that many in the news media now refer to as the "Arab Spring" – a political movement that began in January 2011 in Cairo, Egypt.
- When protestors there assembled and threatened to bring down Hosni Mubarak and his government, the Mubarak administration reacted immediately by shutting down the country's Internet services and mobile phone resources.
- But the protestors had already unified and planned out their organized demonstrations via social media sites such as Facebook and Twitter before the online services in Egypt could be shut down (Ratti and Townsend, 2011).

90



Political Blogs and their Impact for the Democratic Process

- During the 2008 U.S. presidential elections (and again in the 2012 presidential elections), some extreme right-wing political bloggers reported that (then presidential candidate) Barack Obama was a Muslim and that he was not born in the United States.
- Also in 2008, some radical left-wing bloggers reported that (the U.S. vice presidential candidate) Sara Palin's youngest child was really her grandchild and that Palin was protecting her unmarried daughter from embarrassment.

91



Political Blogs and the Democratic Process

- None of these controversial blogs (that included stories about Obama and Palin) was vetted in the way that a report submitted by a professional journalist working for a reputable news organization would be.
- Also, none of these stories would likely have been published in a reputable newspaper or magazine.
- But these stories were read online by numerous people, many of whom had assumed the reports to be true merely because they were published on the Internet.
- Sadly, these kinds of false stories can significantly influence the way that some citizens vote.